

THE FINANCIAL CHECKUP

I HEARD ON THE RADIO THAT INVESTORS SHOULDN'T MAKE A MOVE without getting a full financial checkup from a reputable financial planner. It occurred to me that I'd never undergone a full financial checkup and if there was ever a good time to have one it had to be now, before I engaged in any strenuous money-making.

There were as many financial planners as major household-appliance dealers in the yellow pages of my local phone book. Ten years ago, financial planning wasn't even a category in the yellow pages. Back then, financial planners were hired by rich clients who planned to avoid paying taxes. Thanks to computers, the cost of planning was drastically reduced, and planners began offering their services to the general public.

The idea of an average person having any financial future at all is quite contemporary. I spent several hours in the library browsing through old books, looking for the earliest mention of a financial future as applied to a popular audience. I found it in a 1922 pamphlet. The author, a Mr. Alquist, writes as follows:

Only two and a half per cent of men who die between the ages of 60 and 70 leave enough money for funeral expenses. Do you realize where you're headed if you don't begin to lay plans for your financial future?

What Mr. Alquist meant by "where you're headed" I wouldn't want to guess, but this much is obvious: the idea of a financial future begins with the worry over how to pay the funeral bill. This makes sense when you realize that the funeral bill was the first